

citizens the right to information, right to education and right to food. We did not do the big talk, we performed. We are honest about our guarantees. What were Modi's guarantees? Twenty million jobs every year. Rs 15 lakh in every account. Farmer incomes will be doubled. Skill training for millions of people. Has he fulfilled any of these guarantees? The Congress governments in Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh and Telangana have fulfilled the guarantees promised before the assembly elections. When our guarantees work, Modi simply copies it. He is fooling everyone—the youth, the poor, women and farmers. Whenever we question something, Modi points fingers at us. If we raise the issue of EVMs, he says EVMs existed even when the Congress was in power. The issue is not the technology, but its misuse. A knife can be used to chop vegetables or kill someone. The weapon is the same. Modi is using the same weapons, not for public welfare but to crush the Opposition.

Do you agree? Why didn't the Congress party attend the idol consecration ceremony?

I'm a Dalit. I'm also a Hindu. The meaning of my name Mallikarjun is 'Lord of the mountains', which is another name for Lord Shiva. But I'm not allowed to worship inside a temple. In this country, Dalits are still not allowed to enter temples at many places. Can one invitation solve that problem? Dalits are still not allowed to drink water from the same source that upper caste people use. Marriage processions of Dalits are forcefully stopped. Dalit grooms are beaten if they ride horses. I have never played the caste card, but this is the truth. Dalits are not allowed to enter temples, forget about getting anywhere near the idol. It hurts our self-respect. The BJP says it has made persons from the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes the country's president. But do BJP leaders respect these individuals? When the foundation stone was laid for the new parliament (building), the then president Ram Nath Kovind was not invited. Modi did not let President Droupadi Murmu inaugurate the new parliament building. Even the Shankaracharyas did not attend the consecration [of the temple in Ayodhya]. What the BJP shows on the surface is not true. It has a hidden agenda—unlike the Congress, where there is space for everyone. Coming back to the impact of the Ram temple this election, I think religion is a matter of personal choice and people will not vote based on the mood created by one individual.

> "I'M A DALIT, ALSO A HINDU. BUT I'M NOT ALLOWED TO WORSHIP INSIDE A TEMPLE. IN INDIA, DALITS ARE STILL NOT ALLOWED TO ENTER MANY TEMPLES. CAN ONE [AYODHYA] INVITATION SOLVE THAT PROBLEM?"

Q. The Congress has 25 guarantees to woo voters. How are they different from Modi's guarantees?

We did not give any guarantee in 2004 and 2009. But we delivered. We introduced MGNREGA, we framed laws providing

Q. How do you respond to PM Modi's narrative of delivering a Viksit Bharat?

How many big, employment-generating industries have been set up in the past 10 years? Have you created any fundamental institutions such as the AIIMS, IIM, IIT and IISc? You are just adding to the numbers. Have you enhanced the budget for scientific research? Did Modi send Rakesh Sharma to space? Even the Ram temple is not complete. Modi inaugurated it in a hurry just for electoral gains. Today, employment has gone down. Educated people are feeling that there is no future in India. That's why nearly 1.4 million people have left the country, given up their citizenship.

Q. Why is the caste census such an important issue for the Congress now? Why didn't the UPA government release the findings of the 2011 Socio-Economic and Caste Census?

A caste census is important because the government can frame accurate welfare policies based on this. We were in power only for three years after the data of the 2011 caste census came. The government needed time to consolidate and analyse the data. But the Modi government has been in power for the last 10 years. Why hasn't it released the data?

Q. Don't you think I.N.D.I.A. wasted time ironing out internal squabbles? Nitish Kumar exited, NCP is broken, Mamata Banerjee is fighting solo in West Bengal.... There was a delay in reaching seat-sharing agreements too.

There was no delay. As for Nitish Kumar, his intent wasn't honest. Ours is an ideological alliance. It's not just to grab